

Gen Z is not lost: They are evolving

Every generation faces **scepticism** from the ones before it. “While the Silent Generation viewed the Baby Boomers as overly **rebellious**, the Boomers, in turn, criticised Millennials for being too entitled. Now, **the torch has passed** to Generation Z — and the narrative feels **strikingly** familiar. Some claim, ‘They’re lost,’ while others **remark**, ‘They’re addicted to their phones,’ or ‘They lack a strong work ethic.’ But as we dig deeper beyond the surface-level criticism and viral TikTok, a different picture begins to emerge — the one that reveals **resilience**, reimagination and evolution.

It is **irrefutable** that Gen Z is not lost — rather they are simply not following the traditional **blueprint**. They are **adapting to** the rapidly changing world, questioning outdated systems and are **carving out** new definitions of success, happiness and purpose. **One** of the most noticeable shifts Gen Z is bringing **is** how they approach careers.

While earlier generations often defined success through stability, job security and **upward mobility** in traditional careers, **Gen Z** — on the other hand — **is** redefining it through flexibility, purpose and creative freedom. Consider the story of a young founder who, at just 19, made the **bold** decision to leave behind a world-class university to build a 10-minute grocery delivery startup in India with his friend. By their early twenties, they had turned their vision into a billion-dollar enterprise. This isn’t just a **tale** of success — it’s a powerful example of how this generation chooses innovation over tradition, ownership over **conformity** and purpose over **prestige**.

Today’s young generation is redefining what success looks like. A popular educator and entrepreneur who connects with them regularly on social media has noticed a powerful shift — they’re not chasing titles or just pay cheques. They’re searching for meaning. They crave impact. And they’re not afraid to take risks — be it switching careers, freelancing or launching side **hustles** — all **in pursuit of** something greater.

This isn’t aimlessness; it’s evolution. In a world that’s constantly changing, **adaptability** is a strength. Gen Z isn’t lost — they’re leading the way. They’re **daring** to challenge the norm, break boundaries and build a future that **reflects** their values. And the world would be wise to **pay attention**.

Critics often blame Gen Z for being “glued to screens.” While it’s true they spend significant time online, it’s essential to understand how they use this digital fluency to their advantage. Across the world, young digital creators are doing more than entertaining — they’re **sparking** conversations about mental health, self-awareness, and everyday struggles.

They’re using platforms like YouTube, Instagram, LinkedIn, and Substack not just to share content, but to build meaningful communities and careers. Gen Z is **shattering** the myth that digital spaces are **shallow**. They’re showing us that influence can come from being real, that connection can be built through honesty, and that success doesn’t need to follow the old rules. If Millennials were **labelled**

“woke,” Gen Z is “fiercely awake”. They are more politically and socially active than any previous generation at their age. Whether it’s climate change, gender rights, racial justice or digital privacy, Gen Z doesn’t just talk — they organise, protest and innovate.

Today, many Gen Z learners are exploring alternative education through gap years, **digital bootcamps** and self-taught skills. The pandemic accelerated this trend, proving that knowledge is no longer **confined to** classrooms or textbooks. Gen Z is more open-minded and inclusive than any generation before them.

Conversations around gender identity, sexuality, body image, caste and neurodiversity **are** far more visible and **empathetic**. Even within classrooms and friend circles, Gen Z is less judgemental and more accepting of differences. Schools and colleges are beginning to support LGBTQ+ clubs, mental health societies, and diversity campaigns — some of which are often led by the students themselves.

There is no denying that every generation redefines what it means to live a meaningful life. Gen Z is doing just that — be it climate crises, pandemics, automation or global **upheavals**. Instead of **sticking to** outdated systems, they are evolving to survive and **thrive in** a world that is rapidly changing. Yes, they challenge norms — because those norms are not always fair or inclusive. Gen Z may not be walking the path we expected — but they’re building a new road. And the world would do well to follow their lead.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

Vocabulary

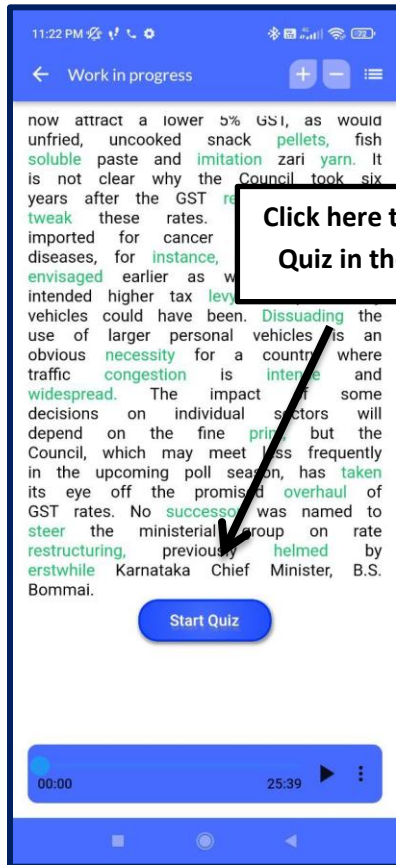
1. **Scepticism** (noun) – doubt, disbelief, suspicion, cynicism, mistrust शक / संदेह economic position सामाजिक या आर्थिक उन्नति
2. **Rebellious** (adjective) – defiant, disobedient, unruly, insurgent, resistant विद्रोही / विरोधी
3. **Pass the torch** (phrase) – to transfer responsibility, power, or leadership from one person to another
4. **Strikingly** (adverb) – remarkably, notably, distinctly, conspicuously, surprisingly आश्चर्यजनक रूप से
5. **Remark** (noun) – comment, observation, statement, note, opinion टिप्पणी
6. **Resilience** (noun) – toughness, strength, endurance, grit, adaptability मजबूती
7. **Irrefutable** (adjective) – undeniable, indisputable, unquestionable, certain, conclusive अपरिवर्तनीय
8. **Blueprint** (noun) – plan, strategy, roadmap, design, outline रूपरेखा
9. **Adapt** (to) (verb) – adjust, modify, accommodate, tailor, conform अनुकूल होना
10. **Carve out** (phrasal verb) – establish, build, create, shape, forge बनाना / गढ़ना
11. **Upward mobility** (noun) – It refers to the ability of an individual, social group, or class to move to a higher social or
12. **Bold** (adjective) – courageous, daring, fearless, brave, audacious साहसी / निर्भीक
13. **Tale** (noun) – story, narrative, account, chronicle, anecdote कहानी
14. **Conformity** (noun) – compliance, obedience, adherence, agreement, alignment अनुरूपता
15. **Prestige** (noun) – status, respect, reputation, honour, influence प्रतिष्ठा
16. **Hustle** (noun) – side job, gig, extra work, effort, venture अतिरिक्त प्रयास या छोटा व्यवसाय
17. **In pursuit of** (phrase) – in search of, aiming for, seeking, striving for, chasing की खोज में
18. **Adaptability** (noun) – flexibility, versatility, adjustability, resilience, responsiveness अनुकूलनशीलता
19. **Dare** (verb) – risk, venture, attempt, challenge, defy साहस करना
20. **Reflect** (verb) – represent, mirror, show, display, indicate प्रतिबिंबित करना
21. **Pay attention** (phrase) – focus, observe, notice, heed, concentrate ध्यान देना

22. **Spark** (verb) – ignite, trigger, stimulate, provoke, initiate शुरुआत करना
23. **Shatter** (verb) – break, destroy, demolish, crush, dismantle तोड़ना / चकनाचूर करना
24. **Shallow** (adjective) – superficial, surface-level, empty, hollow, trivial सतही / छिछला
25. **Label** (verb) – tag, define, name, classify, brand नाम देना
26. **Digital bootcamp** (noun) – an intensive, focused program that helps students and professionals gain an in-depth understanding of the technology, tools, and skills needed to excel in the digital world. डिजिटल कौशल प्रशिक्षण शिविर
27. **Confine** (to) (verb) – restrict, limit, enclose, restrain, bound सीमित करना
28. **Empathetic** (adjective) – compassionate, understanding, sensitive, kind, caring सहानुभूतिपूर्ण
29. **Upheaval** (noun) – disruption, turmoil, disturbance, unrest, chaos उथल-पुथल
30. **Stick** (to) (verb) – follow, adhere to, abide by, cling to, remain with टिके रहना
31. **Thrive** (in) (verb) – flourish, succeed, prosper, grow, bloom फलना-फूलना

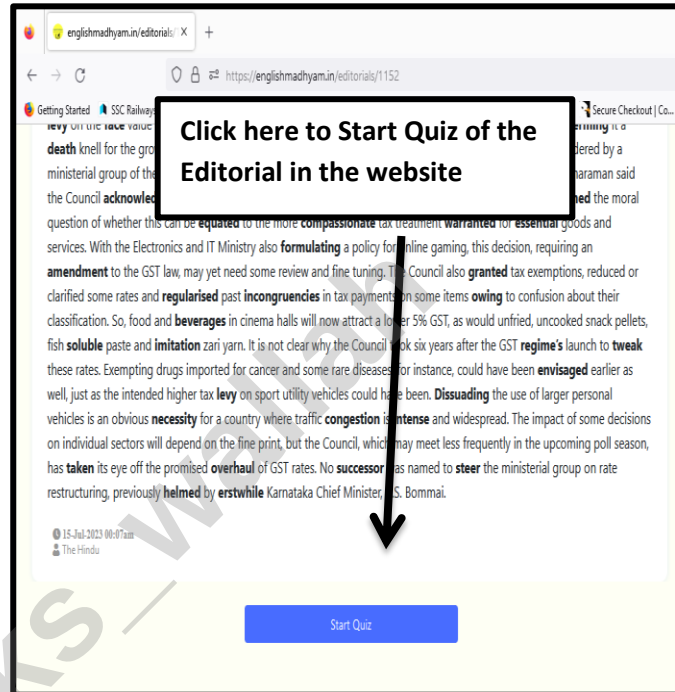
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Recurring Generational Criticism** – Each generation is often misunderstood by the previous one; Gen Z now faces the same scepticism once directed at Boomers and Millennials.
2. **Stereotypes about Gen Z** – They're frequently criticized for being addicted to screens or lacking work ethic, but these are **surface-level observations**.
3. **Challenging Traditional Norms** – Gen Z isn't lost; they're rejecting **outdated definitions of success** and crafting **new values** around purpose and flexibility.
4. **Shift in Career Aspirations** – Unlike previous generations that prioritized stability, Gen Z seeks **creative freedom**, flexibility, and **meaningful work**.
5. **Innovation over Prestige** – A cited example includes a 19-year-old who dropped out of a top university to build a **billion-dollar grocery delivery startup**, showing Gen Z's preference for **bold innovation**.
6. **Risk-Taking Mindset** – Gen Z is open to **freelancing, switching careers, and launching side hustles** in pursuit of fulfillment, not just paychecks.
7. **Digital Fluency as Strength** – While often blamed for screen addiction, Gen Z **leverages digital platforms** like YouTube, LinkedIn, and Instagram to **educate, build communities, and grow careers**.
8. **Content with Purpose** – Online, Gen Z creators address **mental health, identity, and real-life struggles**, offering authenticity rather than superficiality.
9. **Redefining Influence** – They demonstrate that **influence can stem from honesty**, and real connection, challenging traditional media's scripted roles.
10. **Fiercely Socially Active** – Gen Z is more **politically and socially engaged** than earlier generations, actively taking stands on issues like **climate change, gender rights, and digital privacy**.
11. **Alternative Education Paths** – Many Gen Z learners opt for **gap years, bootcamps, and self-learning**, especially post-pandemic, highlighting a **decentralisation of education**.
12. **Inclusive and Open-Minded** – Gen Z is leading conversations on **gender, caste, sexuality, neurodiversity, and body image**, promoting empathy and acceptance.
13. **Institutional Impact** – Schools and colleges are adapting with **LGBTQ+ clubs, mental health initiatives, and diversity campaigns**, often driven by students.
14. **Adaptability as Evolution** – Their **adaptability amid crises** (climate, COVID-19, automation) shows that Gen Z isn't aimless—they are evolving with the world.
15. **Building a New Road** – Gen Z challenges unfair norms and builds new models for living and working, urging society to **rethink its assumptions and follow their lead**.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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